at that stage, but had seen our batting collapse in that match.) After having won the previous edition Down Under in 1992, crashing out in the quarterfinals was a sad moment for Pakistan. Also, it was another bloody World Cup loss to India – a jinx that has now spawned even television commercials whenever the teams face off in ICC tournaments. It's Pakistan's very own Curse of the Bambino, though I'm confident we won't take as long to break it as the Boston Red Sox did.

Thus, as far as India–Pakistan matches were concerned, I was just like any other fan from the two nations – fanatical about the rivalry. But in those days, before the commercialization of cricket really took off, the hype about India–Pak games was real, not superficial or drummed up by social and mainstream media. We felt it on the field as the players faced each other in the middle. The rivalry was raw and genuine, not politicized and commercialized.

In my first match versus India, I disappointed myself more than anyone else. I had a single-digit score next to my name. Nothing much with the ball, either, except catching Rahul Dravid off Aaqib Javed.

But I remember it all clearly. We were in Chennai. I opened with Saeed Anwar. The crowd's roar was the loudest noise I'd ever heard; I felt the earth shaking and I swear I couldn't feel my bat. I'm not sure if I could even see the bowler properly. To be honest, I was scared and hoping that the first ball would come and just pass – off and away. I was at the crease for some nine minutes only, scoring just five off six balls. I wasn't surprised to get out early (caught Sourav Ganguly, bowled Abey Kuruvilla). I remember my head and heart pounding throughout that day. My head, because of the heat, and my heart, because of the noise. Oh, that noise. The sheer noise of the world's greatest rivalry.

But despite getting out early, I would remain in the game. Something unusual happened in that match – an important milestone in Pakistan's and South Asia's cricket history. Something that let the game go on to become one of the greatest matches ever played between India and Pakistan, and I would be in the centre of it.

A few minutes after my dismissal when I was back in the pavilion, I was asked to return to the middle to run for Saeed Anwar, who was injured but still batting well. He was dehydrated thanks to the extreme humidity in Chennai. When he was at 50 or 60, he began to experience severe cramps too.

For Saeed bhai and for Pakistan, I ran a lot that day. It was rough for me – and I ran for almost three hours – and can't imagine how it was for Saeed; he was there for 206 minutes. The heat and humid weather were crazy. But so was the atmosphere, and Saeed bhai was in great touch. He just kept connecting bat to ball, non-stop. By the time he was in the middle of his mammoth 194, setting up what would become a world record for years – beating Viv Richards's thirteen-year-old record of 189 not out against England – the crowd was deflated. Pin-drop silence descended in the stand after he reached a century and it became obvious that Saeed bhai had no intention of giving up. I think my own calls for runs – 'yes', 'no', 'wait', 'double' – were the only audible shouts in the field for most of his innings.

What a day! What an innings! Saeed Anwar at his finest. 194 from 146 balls. Twenty-two fours, 5 sixes – the highlight of the innings being dispatching Anil Kumble for 2, 2, 6, 6, 6 and 4. We set India a target of 328. But even Dravid's century – he too brought Tendulkar as his runner for no clear reason, and we objected, successfully – couldn't help take India home. Pakistan won